

Antonelli's skill and talent were on display right from round one, when he navigated a tricky wet race in Australia to take fourth and score the first points of his career. He also became the youngest driver to lead a race and set a fastest lap in Japan, which was just his third outing as an F1 driver. Add to this a qualifying session where he outpaced the quick McLaren duo, and a driver to look out for was guaranteed.

A spirited sprint

A rain delay and a couple of laps behind the Safety Car — which played a big role later in the 18-lap event — meant Antonelli had to wait longer to get the perfect start. Much to his dismay, his pole glory was short-lived as Piastri got the better of him into Turn 1. Soon after, it was the McLaren pair fighting it out for the top spot. But it first had to deal with an imminent issue — a potential race-altering pit stop.

Heavy showers hit the area prior, leaving the track requiring wet tyres. But the hot and humid conditions in Miami meant teams had to think of switching to slicks or risk losing pace and places.

Ferrari's Hamilton was one of the first front-runners to pit — a move that triggered a chain reaction of drivers diving into the pits. It paid off handsomely for the 40-year-old, who grabbed a podium place — another successful sprint result.

For Antonelli and Max Verstappen, a pit lane incident proved costly. Antonelli lost time, while Verstappen received a 10-second penalty. Meanwhile, Piastri was called in first by McLaren, while Norris followed in a later call that turned out to be a masterstroke.

A crash by Fernando Alonso brought out the Safety Car just as Norris exited the pits, allowing him to retain track position to relive his Miami glory and secure the sprint ahead of Piastri.

Norris may have kept his teammate at bay in the sprint and Verstappen managed to edge Piastri for pole ahead of the main race, but the championship leader left his very best for Sunday.

The Piastri show

There was a possibility of rain interruptions and even a suspension after another bout of heavy rain. However, bad weather was not going to play spoilsport this time.

The drivers' parade took place with life-size LEGO cars driven around the track. The pre-race fun soon gave way to a highly anticipated start under dry yet overcast skies.

Piastri couldn't replicate his first-corner effort but climbed from

fourth to first with a couple of precise, calculated overtakes by lap 14. As has become routine for the Australian, a clean race helped him complete a hat-trick of wins and secure a fourth triumph in six races.

Norris recovered from a poor opening lap to claim second, giving McLaren a strong 1-2 finish — a turnaround from the same affair two years ago, when neither driver scored a point. "Two years ago, here in Miami, we were genuinely the slowest team — I think we got lapped twice," Piastri said at the post-race press conference, referring to when he and Norris finished 19th and 17th respectively.

"And to now have won the Grand Prix by over 35 seconds to third is an unbelievable result," he added, as third-placed George Russell crossed the line more than 37 seconds behind Piastri. The Mercedes driver's strategic gamble paid off after starting with a different tyre compound and even fending off Verstappen in the closing stages.

The pole-sitter curse continued as the Dutchman could only manage fourth, ahead of a standout performance by Williams' Alexander Albon in fifth. Behind them, Antonelli took sixth, while Ferrari endured a frustrating afternoon, bringing home just 10 points combined.

Plenty of positives

For McLaren, the major points haul has given it a whopping 105-point lead over Mercedes in second, only six rounds into the 24-race calendar. And a 16-point cushion over Norris is what Piastri now enjoys. With three race wins splitting the two, the younger driver is starting to assert himself as the team's championship leader.

Yet, if there's one thing Piastri knows well, it's that a late charge from Norris is never off the table — and he'll be ready for it when it comes.



GETTY IMAGES